BOOKS

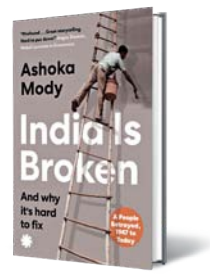
VARIOUS STATES OF THE NATION

By Prosenjit Datta

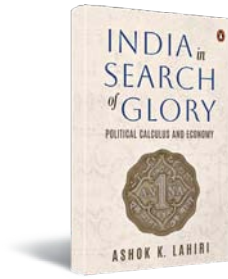
Seventy-five years after India became an independent nation, where do we stand and what does our medium-term future hold? That is a question two recent books by two eminent economists seek to answer. Ashoka Mody, who served as senior economist in IMF and World Bank and is currently Charles and Marie Robertson visiting professor in international economic policy at Princeton's School of Public and International Affairs, thinks that India is irretrievably broken and probably cannot be fixed. Former chief economic advisor Ashok Lahiri, too, had stints with the IMF and the World Bank, apart from teaching economics at the Delhi School of Economics and serving as chairman of Bandhan Bank. Currently a member of the West Bengal legislative assembly, he does not quite share Mody's gloom and doom, though he expects the country's search for glory to be difficult. Lahiri points out that the India story of the past 75 years looks impressive on surface, but loses its shine when compared with the East Asian Tigers or China.

Both books are exceptional works of scholarship and research. They examine in detail the term of each Indian prime minister, the pulls and pushes in the politics of the day, and how these affected economic policies. They also look at the many missteps we have taken in the past 75 years. While both have drawn similar conclusions in many areas, the flavours of the two books are entirely different.

Mody's book is probably the more readable for laymen despite examining the complicated turns in India's politics and economic journey. He does not pull his punches. He looks at India's progress and journey through the primary filter of jobs, or rather India's inability to create enough jobs that are needed for a majority of its citizens to live better lives. He worries about the looming climate crisis and laments that despite debates about net zero carbon emissions, India's environmental degradation is continuing. As he points out, lack of accountability is not a bug in Indian politics—it is a feature.



INDIA IS BROKEN
By Ashoka Mody
JUGGERNAUT
₹899; 536 pages



NDIA IN SEARCH OF GLORY
By Ashok K. Lahiri
PENGUIN
₹1,499; 712 pages

Mody has a flair for story-telling. He is also unsparing in his criticism but never unfair. He is completely unbiased—his prose is equally trenchant whether it deals with Nehru's follies, Indira Gandhi's statism or the current Modi regime. The only prime minister who seems to have been on the right path was the late Lal Bahadur Shastri, who started undoing many of Nehru's policies, but died too early. Mody keeps going back to his central point—the inability of successive Indian governments to create enough jobs for the average Indian. The overall GDP size is, after all, immaterial if it does not translate to not just higher per capita income but a more equal income and wealth distribution.

Lahiri's narration is also very readable—with a caveat. It is the more scholarly of the two and that sometimes slows it down. It gets into details of individual policies, and has plenty of graphs and tables to bolster the points he makes. Occasionally, the author gets into mathematical models and formulations more suited for an economics class than in a book chronicling the political calculus and economy of the past 75 years. But in those details also lies its value to the serious economic researcher. It is the kind of book that economic writers in India may refer to frequently. Lahiri is a member of the BJP and yet his narration and analysis are completely unbiased. He is measured in his tone and even-handed in examining both the good and the bad.

Despite the very different tone of each author, they probably have more in common in their views than differences. If there is one thing slightly disappointing, it is that neither provides any clear-cut solutions. Both proffer some thoughts but these are mostly amorphous. However, even a clear enunciation of problems is valuable—and both Mody and Lahiri do that brilliantly in their own inimitable ways. ■

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